

HUM14 - 3

Philosophy I — The Examined Life

[Module page](#)

Version of 13 September 2026

About this textbook

This year, for the first time, every Bachelor course at Albert School has its own textbook, thanks to your teachers and AI.

- The textbook is a help for working on the course at home, after the class.
- The course as taught in class remains the reference, and prevails over the textbook wherever the two differ.
- This is a first version. Help us improve it by sharing your feedback with your teacher.

Contents

Preface	4
How to use this book	4
1. Turning success into a question	5
1.1. From a given to a question	5
1.2. What a question takes for granted	5
1.3. Asking without hiding your opinion in the question	6
2. Making and supporting a claim	8
2.1. What an argument is, and what it is not	8
2.2. Supporting a claim, and making its presuppositions explicit	8
2.3. Valid and sound	9
3. Objecting, and following an idea to aporia	11
3.1. The three checks	11
3.2. The cardinal rule: separate the conclusion from the argument	11
3.3. Aporia: following an idea to its breaking point	12
4. Conceptualising: defining and distinguishing	14
4.1. When a word carries the disagreement	14
4.2. Defining a notion	14
4.3. Distinguishing the notions of success	14
5. Interpreting	17
5.1. Reading what is not said	17
5.2. Interpreting a story	17
6. Five criteria for a successful life	19
6.1. Aristotle: eudaimonia and the whole life	19
6.2. Epictetus: the dichotomy of control	19
6.3. Spinoza: conatus and joy	20
6.4. Seneca: the happy life versus the merely successful one	21
6.5. Mill: happiness as well-being, and the trouble of measuring it	21
6.6. Using the five together	22
7. Constructing and defending a thesis on success	24
7.1. What a rigorous thesis contains	24
7.2. Being your own adversary	25
7.3. Revising, and holding your ground	26
7.4. Drawing the consequences	26
7.5. Defending under pressure, and composing the essay	27

Preface

This book is about one question — what does it mean to succeed? — and about learning to think it through for yourself, instead of living by an answer you took from others without ever inspecting it.

By the end, you will be able to:

- take a settled notion, such as “a successful life”, and turn it into a genuine question — and see what that question, and your own claims, quietly take for granted;
- state a position and support it with reasons and examples whose steps hold;
- object to a position, your own or someone else’s, and press it until it either holds or breaks down;
- define the notions at stake and tell apart the ones that are easily confused, such as success, happiness, pleasure and flourishing;
- draw out what a question or a story means when it is not said outright;
- revise a position when a sound objection requires it, and keep it, with reasons, when none does;
- write and defend a reasoned essay that proposes a thesis on success, faces the strongest objection to it, and draws out what it asks of a life.

None of these is a fact to memorise. Each is a skill of thinking, and you do not yet hold them in the form this book aims to give you.

How to use this book

This book teaches skills, not facts, and you cannot acquire a skill by reading about it, any more than you can learn to swim from a manual. So read actively. The first five chapters build the moves of the practice one at a time — questioning, arguing, objecting, conceptualising, interpreting. The sixth gives you five instruments for thinking about success: five thinkers, each offering a criterion for a good life. The seventh puts everything to work in a thesis of your own, defended against objection.

Two points about the approach will spare you a common misunderstanding of what “philosophy” means here. First, thinkers enter only as instruments. When we bring one in — Socrates, Aristotle, Epictetus, Spinoza, Seneca or Mill — the question is never “what did this person believe?” It is always “*what does this let us see that we could not see without it?*” A thinker who shows you nothing new is, for this book, of no use, however famous. Second, the only thing that counts is the **rigour of the reasoning**: its premises, its steps, and whether its conclusion really follows. A position earns nothing by agreeing with a famous name, and loses nothing by contradicting one, as long as the reasoning holds. A conclusion you dislike, argued well, is worth more than a conclusion you share, argued badly.

At the end of every chapter there are **exercises**. Do them before you read the answers: the answers are there so that you can check your own work, not so that you can skip it. A position is tested only when someone objects to it, and this book has no classmates. So where a class would press you, the book gives you a substitute: a set of standard objections you can turn on your own claims, and a procedure for testing your own position as an opponent would (Chapter 7). A claim you have tested against objection yourself is worth far more than one you have only accepted.

1. Turning success into a question

Everything in this book starts from one move: taking something you have always treated as an answer and making it a question. This chapter is about that move, and about the first skill it requires — asking a question that opens a real problem instead of hiding an opinion.

1.1. From a given to a question

Example — the inherited scoreboard. Ask most people what a successful life looks like and the answers come quickly and ready-made: a high salary, an impressive title, recognition, the right neighbourhood. Ask *why* these count as success, and the answers become much weaker. Mostly they were absorbed — from family, from friends, from social media, from the surrounding culture — and never inspected. The list is treated as a **given**: something you measure yourself against, not something you ask about.

To **make something a question** is to stop treating it as settled and start asking what it rests on. “Success is a high salary and an impressive title” is a given. “What makes a life successful, and why those things rather than others?” is a question. The difference is not cosmetic. A given can only be met or missed. A question has an inside: it can be opened, and what it assumes can be brought into the open.

Definition 1. A **genuine question** opens a problem: it invites you to look for an answer that is not already decided by the way the question is put. A **loaded question** hides a claim inside itself and only pretends to ask — it has already answered, and merely asks you to agree.

1.2. What a question takes for granted

The reason questioning is a skill, and not just curiosity, is that every question carries **presuppositions**: things that must already be taken as true for the question to make sense as asked. Expose them, and a confident question often turns out to assume exactly what should be examined.

Definition 2. A **presupposition** of a question or a claim is something it takes for granted — something that must hold for the question to be askable, or the claim assertable, in the form given. A presupposition is not stated; it is assumed. The first skill of the examined life is to make the unstated assumption visible.

A question can take things for granted on several levels at once. It helps to sort them.

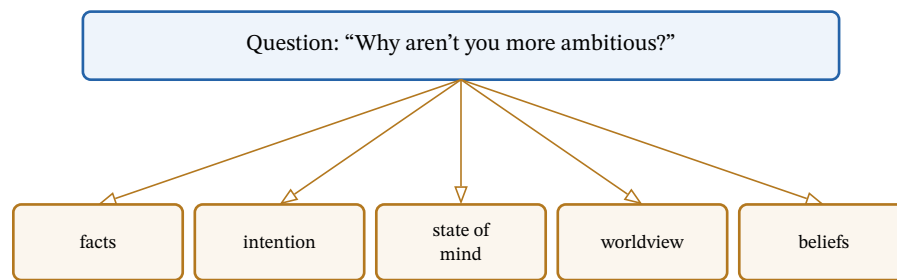


Figure 1: The presuppositions buried in a single question. “Why aren’t you more ambitious?” assumes *facts* (that you are not very ambitious), an *intention* read into you (that you were trying to be and failed), a *state of mind* (that this reflects a real want of yours), a *worldview* (that lives rank on a scale of ambition that matters), and a *belief* (that more ambition would be better). None of these is stated; each can be false. Answering the question as asked concedes all five.

The five layers in Figure 1 are worth naming, because a question can be sound on one and rotten on another:

- **Facts:** what the question assumes is the case (“you are not ambitious”).
- **Intention:** what it assumes you were trying to do (“you meant to be, and fell short”).
- **State of mind:** what it assumes about your inner life (“this is what you actually want”).
- **Worldview:** the picture of how things are ranked or connected that the question relies on (“ambition is the axis on which lives are measured”).
- **Beliefs:** the values it treats as obvious (“more ambition is better”).

Example — surfacing a presupposition. A student says: “I need to decide whether to sell out and take the corporate job, or stay true to myself.” The phrase “sell out” already answers the question: it presupposes that the corporate job is a betrayal of the real self, and that “the real self” is the non-corporate one. Neither is obvious. Surfacing the presupposition — “you are assuming the corporate path is a betrayal; is it?” — reopens a question the loaded phrasing had quietly closed.

1.3. Asking without hiding your opinion in the question

The hardest part of questioning is keeping your own answer out of the question. A question that carries your opinion cannot open a problem, because it has already shut it.

Method 1 (forming a question that opens a problem).

1. **State it as an open question, not a leading one.** “Isn’t recognition obviously worth pursuing?” leads; “What, if anything, makes recognition worth pursuing?” opens.
2. **Check the presuppositions.** Ask what must be true for the question to make sense as posed, across the five layers, and make each assumption explicit.
3. **Remove the ones that beg the question.** If a presupposition is exactly what is in dispute, the question must not assume it. Rephrase until the answer is not decided in advance.

This is the move Socrates makes throughout Plato’s early dialogues, and it is why we take him as the model of the method rather than as a source of doctrine. He meets someone who is sure they know what piety is, or courage, or justice, and he does not argue that they are wrong. He asks: “What is it?” — and then keeps the question open, refusing every answer that turns out to assume what it was supposed to explain. The confident interlocutor is not lectured; he is questioned until he sees that

his certainty rested on assumptions he had never inspected. That is the whole method: not to deliver the answer, but to keep the question genuinely open until the presuppositions surface.

Pitfall. The commonest failure in questioning is the **loaded question**: presenting a claim as if it were a question. “Why do people waste their lives chasing money?” is not a question about money; it is the opinion “chasing money wastes your life” put into the form of a question. It cannot teach you anything, because any answer you accept has already granted the point. When you notice you are asking a question you already know the answer to, you are almost certainly leading, not asking.

Pitfall. A second failure is confusing a question of **fact** with a question of **value**. “Do most graduates earn more in finance?” is a factual question, settled by evidence. “Should you go into finance to earn more?” is a question of value, and no salary figure settles it. Sliding from the first to the second — “the data shows finance pays more, so obviously you should” — buries a value judgement inside a fact. Keep them apart.

Exercises

1.1. For each item, say whether it is a *given* or a *genuine question*, and if it is a given, rewrite it as a genuine question: (a) “A successful career is one that keeps climbing.” (b) “What would make this career worth having?” (c) “Everyone wants recognition, so recognition must matter.” (d) “Isn’t it obvious that security beats risk?”

1.2. Take the question “Why don’t you want a more impressive job?” Surface one presupposition at each of the five layers (facts, intention, state of mind, worldview, beliefs).

1.3. Each question below is loaded. Identify the opinion it hides, then rewrite it as an open question that does not hide that opinion in it. (a) “Why do ambitious people always end up lonely?” (b) “How long will you keep settling for an ordinary life?”

1.4. Classify each as a question of *fact* or of *value*, and explain: (a) “Do people who change careers report higher satisfaction?” (b) “Should you change careers if it makes you happier but poorer?” (c) “Is a life of service better than a life of achievement?”

1.5. Take one thing you currently treat as an obvious mark of a successful life. Write it first as the given you actually hold, then turn it into a genuine question, and list two presuppositions your original given was resting on.

Answers. (1) (a) given → “Does a successful career have to keep climbing, or can it succeed by other measures?” (b) already a genuine question. (c) given (it also hides a bad inference — that what everyone wants must matter) → “Does the fact that people want recognition show that it matters?” (d) loaded given → “Does security beat risk, and under what conditions?” (2) For example — facts: that your job is not impressive; intention: that you were aiming for impressive and missed; state of mind: that impressiveness is something you actually want; worldview: that jobs are ranked on an “impressiveness” axis that matters; belief: that a more impressive job would be a better one. (3) (a) hides “ambition causes loneliness” → “What relationship, if any, is there between ambition and loneliness?” (b) hides “your life is ordinary and that is a failure” → “What would make a life more than ordinary, and is that something worth pursuing?” (4) (a) fact — settled by data on reported satisfaction. (b) value — no datum settles whether the trade is worth it. (c) value — “better” here is a judgement, not a measurement. (5) Self-check: a good answer produces a question whose answer is genuinely not fixed by the wording, and names two assumptions (typically one factual, one about value) that the original given had quietly relied on.

2. Making and supporting a claim

Questioning opens a problem. Sooner or later you have to answer it — to put forward a claim and stand behind it. This chapter is about doing that well: stating a hypothesis and supporting it with reasons whose inferences actually hold.

2.1. What an argument is, and what it is not

Example — two ways of disagreeing. Two students disagree about a course of action. The first says: “I just feel it is wrong. I cannot explain why, but I do.” The second says: “It is wrong because it treats a loyal person as a disposable cost, and treating people as disposable is wrong.” Only the second has made an **argument**. She has stated a general principle (treating people as disposable is wrong), a claim about the case (this action does that), and a conclusion (so it is wrong). You can now engage her: you can challenge the principle, or deny that the case fits it. The first student has given you nothing to engage. You can only agree or shrug.

Definition 3. An **argument** is a set of **premises** offered in support of a **conclusion**. The premises are the claims taken as starting points; the conclusion is the claim they are meant to establish; an **inference** is the step from the premises to the conclusion. When you put a claim forward for discussion and set out to support it, that claim is your **hypothesis**. A report of a feeling, an assertion with no support, or a description of how something feels is **not** an argument, and cannot be examined as one.

We insist on arguments rather than opinions for a practical reason: only an argument can be *examined*. An opinion can be shared or not shared, and that is the end of it. An argument has parts, and each part can be inspected.

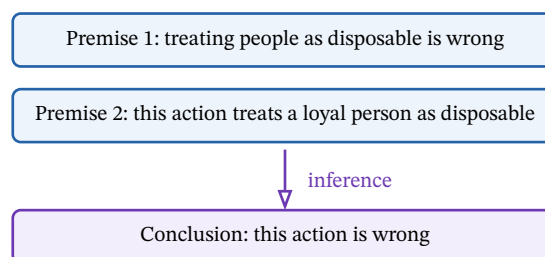


Figure 2: The anatomy of an argument. The premises (blue) are the stated starting points. The conclusion (purple) is what they are meant to establish. The inference is the move between them. An argument can fail at any of these three places: a false premise, a faulty inference, or a conclusion that does not follow even when each premise is granted. Chapter 3 turns each of these into a way of objecting.

2.2. Supporting a claim, and making its presuppositions explicit

A hypothesis is only as good as what holds it up. You support a claim with **reasons** (premises that give grounds for it) and **examples** (cases that show the claim doing real work). But an example is not yet an argument: it illustrates a claim, it does not establish it. The example must be connected to the conclusion by an inference that holds.

The most important discipline in building an argument reaches back to Chapter 1: **make your own presuppositions explicit**. Every argument rests on premises it does not state. Stating them is not a weakness; it is what lets the argument be examined honestly, by you first of all.

Example — the hidden premise. “You should take the promotion — it pays far more.” Stated fully, this argument has a hidden premise: “you should take whatever pays far more.” Once surfaced, the hidden premise looks far less obvious than the original one-liner, and that is the point. A good arguer surfaces it themselves, and either defends it or narrows the claim (“you should take it *if* the extra pay is worth what the role costs you”).

2.3. Valid and sound

Start with an argument that is watertight and worthless at once.

Example — airtight, yet it tells us nothing. “All billionaires are happy. Smith is a billionaire. Therefore Smith is happy.” The reasoning is beyond reproach: if both premises were true, the conclusion would be forced. Yet the first premise is false — plenty of billionaires are miserable — so the conclusion tells us nothing about Smith. The argument is flawless in its logic and useless in its result.

Two words let you say precisely what has gone right and what has gone wrong here.

Definition 4. An argument is **valid** if its conclusion would follow *supposing* the premises were true — the reasoning holds. It is **sound** if it is valid *and* its premises are in fact true. Validity is about the reasoning alone; soundness adds the demand that the starting points be true.

The billionaires argument is **valid** but not **sound**: its reasoning holds, but a false premise sinks it. Validity is necessary but not enough — a watertight inference from a false premise is still worthless.

Aim for soundness in your own arguments: true premises *and* inferences that hold. When you build a hypothesis, aim to make it survive the three checks of Chapter 3 — checks you run on yourself before anyone else runs them on you.

Method 2 (building a defensible hypothesis).

1. **State the claim precisely**, sharply enough that one could argue both for and against it.
2. **Give the reasons** — the premises that support it — and at least one example where the claim does real work.
3. **Surface your own presuppositions**, especially the hidden premise the argument needs but does not say.
4. **Check each inference**, and check that the conclusion does not claim more than the premises license.

Pitfall. The most common substitute for an argument is a **vivid example with no inference attached**. “Look at Jobs — he dropped out and changed the world, so formal education is overrated.” One case is not a general claim, and the leap from “it worked for one famous person”

to “it is overrated in general” is exactly the inference that has been skipped. An example earns its place only when you can state the inference that carries it to the conclusion.

Exercises

2.1. Here is an argument. “Reading fiction makes people more empathetic. Empathetic people make better managers. So companies should encourage their managers to read fiction.” Name the two premises and the conclusion.

2.2. Consider: “Every successful entrepreneur takes risks. Maria takes risks. Therefore Maria is a successful entrepreneur.” Is this argument valid? Is it sound? Explain, using the terms of this chapter.

2.3. “You should move to the city — that is where all the opportunities are.” State the hidden premise this argument needs, then say whether, once surfaced, it is as obvious as the original one-liner made it sound.

2.4. Take a claim about success you actually hold — for example, “it is better to be excellent at one thing than good at many.” Write it as a hypothesis: state the claim, give one reason and one example, and surface the presupposition your argument depends on.

2.5. Build the most defensible short argument you can for the conclusion “a secure job is worth more than a higher-paying but precarious one.” Then name your own weakest premise — the one an opponent would attack first.

Answers. (1) Premise 1: reading fiction makes people more empathetic. Premise 2: empathetic people make better managers. Conclusion: companies should encourage managers to read fiction. (2) The argument is **invalid**, so it cannot be sound. Even if every successful entrepreneur takes risks, it does not follow that everyone who takes risks is a successful entrepreneur — most risk-takers are not. The inference runs the premise backwards. (3) Hidden premise: “you should go where the opportunities are (whatever they cost you).” Surfaced, it is far less obvious — it ignores what leaving costs, and whether the opportunities are ones you want. (4) Self-check: a good answer states a real reason (not the claim restated), gives a genuine example, and names an assumption the argument needs — for instance, that depth is more valuable than breadth in the field you have in mind, which is not true everywhere. (5) Self-check: a strong answer gives true, relevant premises and an inference that holds, and then honestly points to the premise most open to attack (often the implicit claim that security is worth the earnings given up), rather than declaring every premise obvious.

3. Objecting, and following an idea to *aporia*

To object is not to disagree loudly. It is to show, precisely, what does not hold in a claim — your own or someone else’s — and to push it until it either survives or breaks. This chapter gives you the tools to object well, and introduces the place a serious objection can lead: **aporia**.

3.1. The three checks

An argument (Figure 2) can fail in exactly three places, so there are exactly three checks. You run them *whether or not you like the conclusion*.

Method 3 (the three checks).

1. **Are the premises true, or at least defensible?** An argument built on a false starting point proves nothing, however neatly it proceeds.
2. **Does each inference follow?** Granting the premises, is each step really allowed, or has something extra been quietly assumed?
3. **Does the conclusion follow from the premises taken together?** Sometimes every step looks fine, but a key word has shifted meaning along the way, or the conclusion claims more than the premises support.

The sharpest single form of objection is the **counterexample**: one clear case in which the claim’s own terms are met and yet its conclusion plainly fails. A counterexample does not need a theory. It needs one undeniable case, and it can bring down a confident generalisation on its own.

Example — a counterexample at work. Claim: “A successful life is a life of high achievement.” Counterexample: a celebrated surgeon, decorated and productive, who is bitter, friendless and would undo it all for one honest relationship. If that life can be full of achievement and still fail to be one we would call successful, then achievement cannot be *what* success is. The single case forces the claim to narrow or fall.

3.2. The cardinal rule: separate the conclusion from the argument

Pitfall. The most common error in evaluation, and the one to be strictest about, is letting your agreement or disagreement with the *conclusion* decide your verdict on the *argument*. A conclusion you agree with can rest on a bad argument; a conclusion you find wrong can rest on an excellent one. When you find yourself calling an argument “good” and notice you only mean “I agree with where it ends up,” run the three checks again from the start. Objecting well means being as strict with the arguments you like as with the ones you do not.

3.3. Aporia: following an idea to its breaking point

When you press a claim with objections, one of two things happens. Either it survives — repaired, narrowed, better for the pressure — or it reaches a point where every available answer fails, and the confident position dissolves. That second outcome has a name.

Definition 5. Aporia (Greek: “no way through”) is the impasse a position reaches when it is pressed until it can no longer stand as stated: each defence of it either contradicts something already granted or assumes what was to be shown. Aporia is not the same as being confused. It is the *precise* recognition that a position you were sure of does not hold, and *why*.

Reaching aporia is the engine of Socrates’ method. In Plato’s early dialogues someone offers a confident definition — of piety, of courage, of justice — Socrates draws out what it commits them to, produces a case where it fails, the definition is revised, and the revised version fails in turn, until the interlocutor arrives at *I no longer know what I thought I knew*. That arrival is not the failure of the enquiry. It is its first real result.

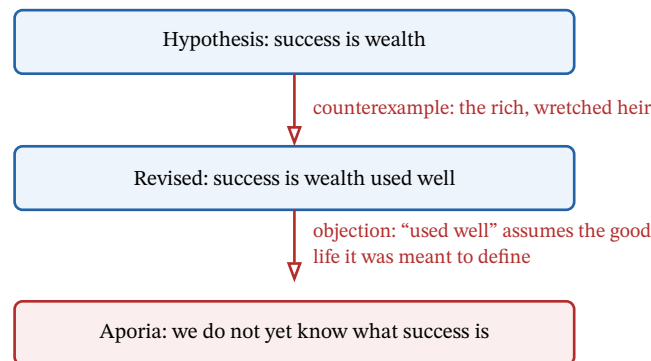


Figure 3: The path to aporia. A confident hypothesis is met with a counterexample, revised, and met again; the revision turns out to assume the very thing it was meant to explain. The end state is not defeat but a cleared ground: the easy answers are gone, and the real question — what *is* success? — now stands exposed. This is the movement Chapter 7 asks you to run against your own thesis.

The value of aporia is that it *clears the ground*: it removes the false answers. Before it, you had a confident answer blocking the question. After it, the false answers are gone and the genuine question is finally in view. Most real philosophical progress begins here: you cannot look for a good answer while a bad one occupies the space.

Pitfall. Aporia is easy to misread as “so nothing can be known — every view is as good as every other.” That inverts it. Reaching aporia is a **precise** result: it shows that *these particular* answers fail, and exactly why. It does not show that no answer exists, and it gives no excuse to give up. The honest response to aporia is to keep working — with the bad answers now ruled out — not to conclude that working is pointless.

Exercises

3.1. Objecting means locating the failure. For this argument, say which of the three checks it fails and where: “People who meditate are calmer. Calm people make better decisions. So everyone should meditate before every decision.”

3.2. Give a counterexample to each claim, and say what the claim must narrow to in order to survive it: (a) “A successful person is one others admire.” (b) “If you work hard enough, you will succeed.”

3.3. A friend argues: “Cheating on this exam is fine, because everyone else is doing it, and you should not put yourself at a disadvantage.” Suppose you strongly disagree with the conclusion. Object to the *argument* anyway: which checks does it fail, and where? Note that you reached the verdict without leaning on your dislike of the conclusion.

3.4. Take the claim “success is being recognised by your peers.” Press it: state it, raise a counterexample, revise it, then raise an objection to the revision. Do you reach a stable position or an aporia? Show the step where it breaks, if it breaks.

3.5. Take one belief you hold about how to live or work and run the three checks on it yourself, pushing until it either survives (say why) or reaches an aporia (show the exact step where every defence fails).

Answers. (1) Mainly check 3: even granting both premises, “should meditate before *every* decision” overreaches — the premises support meditating before *important* decisions at most, and ignore the cost of delaying every trivial one. Check 1 is also shaky (both premises are broad generalisations). (2) (a) Counterexample: a demagogue widely admired for terrible reasons — admiration can track the wrong things; narrow to “admired *for a life actually worth admiring*,” which pushes the question back onto what that is. (b) Counterexample: people who work extremely hard and fail through bad luck or circumstance; narrow to “hard work *raises the chances of* success,” dropping the guarantee. (3) Check 1: “everyone else is doing it” is probably false and, even if true, irrelevant to whether the act is right; and the hidden premise “you should never put yourself at a disadvantage” is indefensible as stated. The reasoning fails on its own terms, independent of the conclusion. (4) Pressing: “recognised by peers” meets a counterexample (someone recognised for work they know to be hollow); revise to “recognised *for genuinely good work*”; but now “genuinely good” is doing all the work and recognition none — the revision assumes the standard of good it was supposed to supply. That is an aporia: recognition cannot be what success *is*. (5) Self-check: a good answer either defends the belief through the three checks or exhibits the precise step at which every repair either contradicts something already granted or assumes what it was meant to establish.

4. Conceptualising: defining and distinguishing

Many disagreements are not disagreements at all — they are two people using the same word for different things. And many questions cannot even be answered until the key notion is made sharp. Conceptualising is the skill of defining a notion, and distinguishing it from its neighbours, precisely enough to think with.

4.1. When a word carries the disagreement

Example — two meanings of one word. Two friends argue for an hour about whether a mutual acquaintance is “successful.” One means *well-off and well-known* — the other means *living a life worth living*. They never disagree about a single fact about the acquaintance’s life. The entire dispute is carried by the word “successful,” which each is using for a different thing. Until the word is pinned down, there is nothing real to argue about.

Definition 6. To **conceptualise** is to **define** a notion (say what it is and is not), **distinguish** it from notions it is easily confused with, and **articulate** how the related notions fit together. A good conceptualisation turns a vague word you argue *with* into a sharp notion you can argue *about*.

4.2. Defining a notion

A definition is tested by cases. A good one is neither too **broad** (it lets in things that plainly are not instances) nor too **narrow** (it excludes things that plainly are). You sharpen a definition the way you press a hypothesis in Chapter 3: propose it, find a case it gets wrong, and adjust.

Method 4 (sharpening a notion).

1. **Gather clear cases** on both sides: things the notion plainly covers, and things it plainly does not.
2. **Propose a mark** — a feature that the yes-cases share and the no-cases lack.
3. **Test it** against the cases. If a no-case has the mark, the definition is too broad; if a yes-case lacks it, too narrow.
4. **Adjust and re-test**, until the mark includes every yes-case and excludes every no-case.

4.3. Distinguishing the notions of success

The central conceptual work of this course is to pull apart four notions that ordinary talk runs together. They are not synonyms, and the differences carry the whole argument of the book.

Notion	Roughly	What it is not
Success	Standing high on some external scale: wealth, status, recognition.	Not the same as being <i>well</i> — the scale may measure the wrong thing.
Happiness	A favourable inner state: one's own life felt, from the inside, as going well.	Not the same as pleasure (it is longer-range, about the whole of a life) nor as flourishing (happiness is <i>felt</i> flourishing is a life actually going well, whether or not it is felt so).
Pleasure	A pleasant feeling in the moment.	Not happiness: a life can be full of pleasures and still not be a happy one.
Flourishing	A life actually going well as a whole, in activity and not merely as a feeling.	Not mere pleasure and not mere success, and not the same as happiness: it is a verdict on a <i>life</i> in activity, which can hold even when the feeling of happiness is absent, and fail even when it is present.

Table 1: Four notions ordinary talk treats as one. **Success** is external and measured; **happiness** is how one's own life feels from the inside; **pleasure** is momentary feeling; **flourishing** is a whole life actually going well in activity, whether or not it feels that way. Keeping them apart is what lets the book's central question — whether a *successful* life is a *good* one — even be asked. Chapter 6 supplies the thinkers who each define one of these more sharply.

Three distinctions do the work. **Success versus happiness**: one is an external score, the other an inner state, and they can come apart — the person highest on the scoreboard need not be the one whose life feels good, or is good. **Pleasure versus flourishing**: one is a feeling in the moment, the other a verdict on a life; an evening can be pleasant, and a life made only of such evenings can still seem wasted. And the subtlest pair, **happiness versus flourishing**: happiness is how a life feels from the inside; flourishing is whether the life is actually going well, in activity. The two usually go together, but they can separate — a person can feel content while their life, judged as a whole, is going badly, and a demanding life can be genuinely flourishing without feeling happy the whole way through. That last distinction — feeling versus a life actually going well — is the one Aristotle builds a whole framework on (Chapter 6).

Pitfall. Before any dispute about the good life, ask whether it is **verbal** or **real**. A verbal dispute is one that would vanish if the two sides fixed their terms (“he is successful” / “he is *not*” — where one means wealthy and the other means fulfilled). A real dispute survives the fixing: the two sides agree on what the words mean and still disagree about the case. Do not spend an hour on a verbal dispute dressed as a real one. Fix the word first.

Exercises

4.1. A proposed definition: “A successful person is one who has achieved their goals.” Give one case that shows it too *broad* and one that shows it too *narrow*, then repair it.

4.2. Using Table 1, place each in the right notion(s) and justify: (a) a weekend of great food and rest; (b) a decades-long body of work the person is proud of; (c) a large fortune inherited and squandered; (d) a quiet life of close friendships and absorbing work.

4.3. Distinguish *pleasure* from *flourishing* using a single example in which the two point in opposite directions, and state the mark that separates them.

4.4. Two people argue about whether an artist who died poor and unknown but did work she loved was “successful.” Show how to tell whether their dispute is verbal or real, and what each would have to say for it to be real.

4.5. Take a notion you use to judge lives (“driven,” “settled,” “free,” ...). Sharpen it with the four-step method: two yes-cases, two no-cases, a mark, and a test that catches at least one case your first attempt got wrong.

Answers. (1) Too broad: someone whose only goal was to be left alone and achieved it — goal-achievement alone does not make a life successful if the goals were empty. Too narrow: someone widely regarded as hugely successful who never set explicit goals at all. Repair: tie success not to *any* achieved goals but to goals *worth* achieving — which pushes the question onto what makes a goal worth it. (2) (a) pleasure. (b) success and, if she values it, flourishing. (c) success in the thin external sense only, and not even that for long — neither happiness nor flourishing. (d) happiness and flourishing, with little conventional success. (3) Example: an addict’s high is intense pleasure while the life around it collapses — maximal pleasure, minimal flourishing. The mark: pleasure is a momentary feeling; flourishing is a property of the whole life’s activity, which the pleasure is actively undermining. (4) It is verbal if they simply mean different things by “successful” (external recognition vs a life well spent) — fix the word and the disagreement dissolves. It is real only if they agree on a meaning — say, “a life that went well as a whole” — and *still* disagree about whether the artist’s life qualifies. (5) Self-check: a good answer produces a mark that visibly re-sorts at least one case the first attempt misclassified, showing the definition actually did some work.

5. Interpreting

Not everything is said outright. A question can mean more than it asks; a story can carry a point it never states. Interpreting is the skill of drawing out what is not explicit — the intention behind a question, the point of a text or a tale — and doing so in a way the words actually support.

5.1. Reading what is not said

Example — the question behind the question. A colleague asks, apparently idly, “Do you think it is ever too late to change career?” Taken literally, it is a question about age and feasibility. But the way it is asked — to you, now, with that weight — suggests the real question is not factual at all. It is closer to: “Would it be foolish, or forgivable, for me to leave what I have built?” Answering the literal question (“no, people retrain at fifty all the time”) misses the person entirely. Interpreting means hearing the question that is actually being asked.

Definition 7. To **interpret** is to draw out a meaning that is not stated explicitly: the **intention** behind a question (what the asker is really after), or the **point** of a text or story (the claim it makes without asserting it). An interpretation is not a free invention: it is a claim about meaning, and like any claim it must be **supported** — here, by the text and the situation.

Method 5 (interpreting a question or a text).

1. **Ask what problem is really in play.** What is the asker, or the text, actually wrestling with, beneath the literal words?
2. **Read the signals.** Word choice, what is emphasised, what is left out, the situation in which it is said — these carry the meaning the surface omits.
3. **State the point as a claim,** one that could be argued for or against.
4. **Check it against the text.** A good interpretation is supported by what is actually there; discard readings the text will not bear.

5.2. Interpreting a story

A story states nothing and can still make a claim. Reading it is a matter of finding the point it enacts.

Example — the fisherman and the consultant. A management consultant on holiday finds a fisherman dozing beside his boat, the day’s small catch already sold. “If you fished more hours,” says the consultant, “you could buy a second boat, then a fleet, sell the company, and get rich.” “And then?” asks the fisherman. “Then you could relax, sleep in the sun, and fish a little for pleasure.” “But,” says the fisherman, “that is what I am doing now.”

The tale asserts no thesis. Yet its point is unmistakable once you read for it: the consultant’s whole ladder of success leads back to the life the fisherman already has, which exposes the ladder as possibly pointless. **But read carefully.** The story is not a proof that ambition is worthless — that would be over-reading it. It makes one sharp point (an inherited idea of success can send you on a long journey back to where you already were) and leaves open what the consultant might fairly

answer (that security, choice, and not depending on one good season are real goods the fisherman lacks). The disciplined reading states the point *and* its limit.

Pitfall. Interpretation fails in two opposite directions. **Under-reading** takes everything literally and misses the point — hearing “is it too late?” as a question about age, or the fisherman tale as advice about boats. **Over-reading** imposes your own thesis on the material and calls it the meaning — announcing that the tale “proves ambition is a disease,” which the story neither says nor supports. The corrective for both is the same: tie every claim about meaning to something actually in the words or the situation.

Exercises

5.1. For each, give the literal question and then the likely *real* question behind it, and name the signal that tells them apart: (a) a student, the night before results, asks “Does the grade even matter in the long run?” (b) someone who has just been promoted asks a friend, “Do you think I have changed?”

5.2. A one-line tale: “A man spent his life building a taller and taller tower so that he could see further; by the time it was tall enough, he had forgotten what he had wanted to see.” State the point in one sentence, as a claim, and name the detail in the tale that supports it.

5.3. Give one *under-reading* and one *over-reading* of the fisherman tale, and say in each case what the reading ignores or invents.

5.4. Take a short saying you have heard about success or work (for example, “the obstacle is the way”). State what it is really claiming, argue for your reading from its words, and note one thing it leaves unsaid that a critic could press.

Answers. (1) (a) Literal: whether grades predict long-run outcomes. Real: “if I did badly, is it a catastrophe or survivable?” — the signal is the timing (spoken in fear the night before results), not a genuine interest in longitudinal data. (b) Literal: whether the friend has noticed a change. Real: “have I become someone I would not like?” — the signal is that the worry surfaces exactly at the promotion. (2) Point: pursuing a means so single-mindedly can make you lose the end it was for. Support: the man forgets *what he wanted to see* — the detail that the goal, not just the tower, is what he loses. (3) Under-reading: “it is about work-life balance for fishermen” — ignores that the tale is a parable about ends and means generally. Over-reading: “it proves that all ambition is self-defeating” — invents a universal thesis the tale does not argue and cannot support (it shows one ladder folding back on itself, not that every ladder does). (4) Self-check: a good answer states a definite claim, quotes or points to the words that carry it, and honestly flags what the saying omits (for “the obstacle is the way,” that some obstacles are simply harmful and not opportunities in disguise).

6. Five criteria for a successful life

The first five chapters built the moves of the practice. Now we put five **instruments** in your hands: five thinkers, each offering a criterion for judging whether a life or a desire counts as good. We do not ask which is “correct.” We ask what each one *reveals*, and what it is blind to. Each is met as a short extract and used as a tool, in the spirit of Chapter 5: the question is always “what does this let us see?”, never “what did this person believe?”

6.1. Aristotle: eudaimonia and the whole life

Example — the pleasant evening versus the good life. An evening of easy pleasure — good food, good company, nothing demanded of you — is plainly enjoyable. Yet a life made of nothing but such evenings, year after year, strikes most people as somehow wasted, even if it is pleasant the whole way through. That reaction — that a life can be pleasant and still not *good* — is exactly what Aristotle’s criterion is built to explain. It is the pleasure/flourishing distinction of Table 1, turned into a test.

Framework 1 (Aristotle: eudaimonia). For Aristotle the highest human good is **eudaimonia**, usually translated as “flourishing” or “living well.” It is not a feeling or a passing state. It is an **activity of the soul across a complete life**, lived in accordance with reason and virtue. A desire or a goal is good to the degree that pursuing it contributes to such a flourishing life, rather than to passing pleasure or an external reward.

The diagnostic question Aristotle hands you is: *does acting on this move me toward a life that is good taken as a whole?* Eudaimonia is the test, and its span — a *complete life*, not a moment — is what makes it a tool rather than a slogan. **Its blind spot:** it says little about where a desire came from, or how it feels from the inside right now.

6.2. Epictetus: the dichotomy of control

Example — the delayed flight. Your flight is cancelled and you will miss an important meeting. One traveller rages at the gate agent, refreshes the app, and is miserable for hours. Another accepts within seconds that the cancellation is not hers to undo, and turns to what *is* hers: rebooking, a calm message to the meeting, using the time. Same event. The difference is entirely in where each traveller put their effort.

Framework 2 (Epictetus: the dichotomy of control). Epictetus, a Stoic, starts from the **dichotomy of control**. Some things are **up to us** and some are **not up to us**. Up to us are our judgements, our choices, our desires and our responses. Not up to us are external events, our body, our reputation, our wealth, and the actions of other people. Freedom and calm come from investing effort and identity **only** in what is up to us, and accepting the rest.

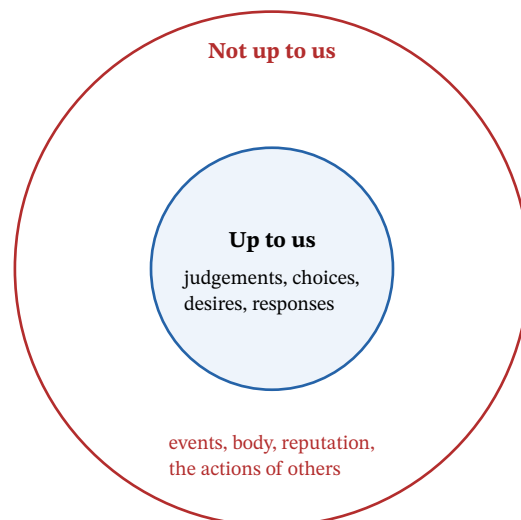


Figure 4: Epictetus's dichotomy of control. The Stoic discipline is to keep effort and self-worth inside the inner circle (what is genuinely up to us) and to accept the outer ring (what is not) rather than staking your peace on it. As a criterion of success it says: a life goes well when it is built on what is yours to command, not on the outer ring that fortune can take back.

The diagnostic move is a sorting one: faced with a goal or a setback, draw the line — what here is genuinely up to me, and what am I merely suffering as if it were? A success staked on the outer ring (reputation, others' approval) is, for Epictetus, never secure. **Its blind spot:** the line can be misused as an excuse for passivity, and the framework says little about which of the things up to us are worth pursuing.

Pitfall. The dichotomy is easy to misread as passivity: “the outcome is not up to me, so I will do nothing.” That inverts it. What is up to you is the **choice and the effort you commit to it**. What is not up to you is the **result**. Epictetus asks for full effort on the choice and calm about the result — not withdrawal.

6.3. Spinoza: conatus and joy

Example — two promotions. Two people take demanding promotions. A year later, the first is more capable, more connected, and more able to make things happen — the role has enlarged her. The second is anxious, dependent on the approval the title brings, and less able to act freely than before — the role has diminished him, even though the title is impressive. Same external success, opposite effect on the person.

Framework 3 (Spinoza: conatus and joy). For Spinoza, each thing strives to persevere in its own being; this striving is the **conatus**. **Joy** is the felt **increase** of your power to act; **sadness** is its decrease. A desire or a goal is to be judged by whether acting on it **increases your genuine power to act** — and so your joy — or shrinks it.

The diagnostic question here is internal: *does acting on this enlarge my power to act, or shrink it?* Unlike Aristotle's test, it does not appeal to a picture of the whole good life; it asks only what the goal *does to you*. In the example, the first promotion increases the power to act (joy), the second decreases

it (sadness), whatever the prestige. **Its blind spot:** it ignores both the origin of a desire and its place in a life taken as a whole.

6.4. Seneca: the happy life versus the merely successful one

Example — the life that looks good only from outside. Picture a life that looks perfect from outside: wealth, a famous name, invitations everywhere, the constant approval of the crowd. Now learn that the person inside it is restless, fearful of losing it all, and unable to say what any of it is *for*. The life looks successful from outside and is wretched from within. Seneca's whole criterion turns on that gap — between a life that *looks* successful and one that *is* good.

Framework 4 (Seneca: the happy life). In *On the Happy Life*, Seneca argues that the happy life (*vita beata*) is one lived in accordance with **reason and virtue**, self-possessed and free of the fear of loss — not one measured by wealth, pleasure, or the crowd's approval. The approval of the many, he insists, is **no evidence** of a good life; often the reverse. The test is to strip a life of **fortune and applause** and ask what remains that is genuinely its own.

The diagnostic question is subtractive: *if I removed the money, the status and the applause, what of this life would still stand?* Whatever survives that subtraction is the part that was really yours; whatever vanishes was borrowed from fortune and the crowd. This is the sharpest tool the course offers against the inherited scoreboard, because it targets exactly the external markers the scoreboard is made of. **Its blind spot:** pressed too far, “strip away all externals” can sound as if health, security and friends count for nothing — which even Seneca does not quite hold, and which Aristotle (external goods matter) directly disputes.

6.5. Mill: happiness as well-being, and the trouble of measuring it

Example — the satisfied fool. Offered a life of simple, reliable contentment — untroubled, undemanding, mildly pleased throughout — many people hesitate to call it the best life, even though it scores high on sheer contentment. Something in us ranks a harder, richer, sometimes discontented life above it. Mill takes that intuition seriously and tries to build it into the account of happiness itself.

Framework 5 (Mill: utilitarian happiness). For Mill, the good is **happiness**, understood as well-being: pleasure and the absence of pain. Not all pleasures count equally: Mill distinguishes **higher** pleasures (of intellect, feeling, and character) from **lower** ones, holding that “it is better to be Socrates dissatisfied than a fool satisfied.” What makes the view **utilitarian** is the standard it sets: an action, a choice or a life is judged by how much well-being it produces **for everyone it affects, each person's well-being counting equally** — your own no more than anyone else's. The good, on this view, is the **greatest total well-being**, weighted toward the higher pleasures.

The diagnostic question is aggregative and impartial: *does this add to well-being — not only mine, but that of everyone it affects — counting the higher goods for more?* Alone among the five criteria, Mill's looks beyond the person whose life is in question to its effect on others; a life aimed only at one's own well-being already misses his standard. It is also the most measurable in ambition — it points at

outcomes you can, roughly, add up. **Its blind spot** — **which Mill himself flags**: well-being is **hard to measure**, and the higher/lower distinction resists any clean scale, so the criterion often cannot say *how much* one course of life exceeds another, only that it does.

6.6. Using the five together

The point is not to pick one criterion. It is to run several over the same life or desire and watch them disagree — because each is blind to what the others see.

Thinker	The question it puts to a life or desire	Its blind spot
Aristotle (eudaimonia)	Does this contribute to a flourishing life taken as a whole?	Says little about a desire's origin or its felt effect now.
Epictetus (dichotomy of control)	Is this built on what is up to me, or staked on the outer ring?	Can slide into passivity; silent on which controllable goods are worth it.
Spinoza (conatus)	Does acting on this increase or decrease my power to act?	Ignores the desire's origin and its place in a whole life.
Seneca (the happy life)	Stripped of fortune and applause, what of this still stands?	Pushed hard, seems to discount external goods (health, security, friends).
Mill (well-being)	Does this add to the well-being of everyone affected, higher pleasures weighted more?	Well-being resists measurement; often cannot say by how much.

Table 2: Five criteria for a successful life as competing instruments. A single case — a visible, high-status job with little real growth — can pass one test and fail another: Seneca and Spinoza distrust it (borrowed approval; shrinking power to act), Mill is unsure (hard to measure), while Aristotle stays open (it might still fit a flourishing life). The disagreement is the information. Chapter 7 asks you to put two of these into productive tension.

Remark. Seneca's subtractive question — *what survives if fortune is stripped away?* — is simply invisible to Mill, who is summing well-being across everyone affected, including the goods fortune supplies. Spinoza's question — *what does this do to my power to act?* — is invisible to Aristotle, who takes the desire as given and asks only where it leads. That is why we hold five instruments rather than one: each sees a dimension the others cannot.

Exercises

6.1. Match each thinker to the one question it puts to a desire: Aristotle, Epictetus, Spinoza, Seneca, Mill. Questions: (a) does this grow or shrink my power to act? (b) stripped of fortune and applause, what remains? (c) does this fit a whole life lived well? (d) does this add to the well-being of everyone affected? (e) is this built on what is up to me?

6.2. A colleague wins a prestigious award voted on by peers, and you find yourself wanting one too. State briefly what each of the five criteria says about pursuing it.

6.3. Design (or recall) a real case on which the five criteria *disagree*: at least one approves and at least one distrusts the same goal. Explain the disagreement, and say what information it gives you that a single criterion would have hidden.

6.4. Read this one-line extract in the spirit of Chapter 5: Epictetus writes that we are disturbed “not by things, but by our judgements about things.” State what this lets you see about a recent setback of your own that the setback itself did not show.

6.5. Take one real ambition of your own that you treat as obviously worth having. Run all five criteria over it. Be especially honest with Seneca’s subtraction and Spinoza’s question.

Answers. (1) Aristotle → (c); Epictetus → (e); Spinoza → (a); Seneca → (b); Mill → (d). (2) Seneca: an award is the crowd’s approval, concentrated into a single prize — strip it away and ask what remains; likely little of your own. Spinoza: does winning it enlarge your power to act, or only your standing in others’ eyes? Epictetus: the vote is not up to you (it depends on peers), so staking your peace on it is staking it on the outer ring. Aristotle: an award is a passing external good; it does little for a flourishing life, though it need not be against one. Mill: judged by total well-being, the award adds a little (recognition is pleasant, may open doors) but touches few people besides you, and the gain is small and hard to measure. (3) A strong answer names the specific clash — e.g. a demanding public career that Seneca and Spinoza flag (borrowed approval, shrinking power to act) yet Aristotle could still count toward flourishing if it builds real virtues — and draws the lesson that “I want it,” “it is good for me,” and “it is really mine” are separate questions that can come apart. (4) Self-check: a good answer relocates the disturbance from the event (outer ring) to a judgement you made about it (up to you), and shows what that reframing opens — not a denial that the setback was real, but a recognition of which part of the pain was yours to revise. (5) Self-check: Seneca’s subtraction should make you at least slightly uncomfortable; if it did not, you probably ran it on an ambition you had already decided was safe.

7. Constructing and defending a thesis on success

This book ends where the practice ends: in a **defended personal thesis** on what it means to succeed. Here every earlier skill is put to work at once — questioning, arguing, objecting, conceptualising, interpreting, and the five criteria. It is judged, like everything here, only on the rigour of the reasoning, never on whether the reader shares your conclusion.

7.1. What a rigorous thesis contains

Method 6 (the five parts of a rigorous thesis).

1. **A clear claim** about what it means to succeed, stated precisely enough that one could argue both for and against it.
2. **Two thinkers in productive tension**: two of the five criteria used *together*, so that their disagreement does real work, rather than one cited as a decorative authority.
3. **A serious counter-argument**: the strongest objection to your claim, stated in its most forceful form.
4. **An answer to that objection**, delivered and then **defended** against further objection — revising the claim where the objection is sound, holding it with reasons where it is not.
5. **The consequences drawn**: what your account of success, once it has survived objection, *asks of a life* — the choices it forces, the comforts it removes, what it commits you to and what it rules out. A thesis that says what success *is* and never what follows from it has done only half the work.

Below is a worked thesis carrying all five parts. Study its shape; then the exercises ask you to build one of your own.

Example — a full worked thesis.

1. The claim.

“To succeed is to build a life organised around increasing your genuine power to act. Status and recognition are worth pursuing only where they also increase that power, and not for their own sake.”

2. Two thinkers in productive tension.

Spinoza supplies the core: joy is the increase of power to act, so a life aimed at that is a life aimed at joy. But Aristotle pushes back *from within* the argument: eudaimonia, a flourishing life, plausibly needs *external and social goods* too — friends, standing, some security — which pure “power to act” seems to discount. The thesis lives in that tension. Seneca is used to reveal how much of what we call “status” is in fact borrowed approval that would not survive his subtraction.

3. The strongest counter-argument, stated as if I held it.

“This thesis is a comfortable idea that only suits people who are already secure. For many people, genuine power to act *depends* on exactly the status it wants to set aside: money, networks, recognition and security are what let a person act at all. To tell them to pursue power to act rather than

status is to tell those who are already secure to enjoy a freedom that those who are not secure cannot afford. Aristotle is right that flourishing needs external goods, and Spinoza's inner power is a luxury."

4. The answer, and the defence.

I concede the true part, and it is a large one: status that buys real capability — security that lets you take risks, a network that lets you act, money that buys time — genuinely increases power to act, and my thesis *welcomes* it. For someone not yet secure, pursuing exactly that money and security *is* pursuing power to act, and my thesis endorses it without reservation. So where the objection insists that external goods matter, it is not attacking my thesis; it is restating a part of it.

The objection's charge — "a luxury only the secure can afford" — nonetheless rests on a hidden premise: that my thesis tells people to set status aside, to pursue power to act *instead of* the money and security they need. That premise is false (check 1 of Chapter 3): the thesis was never "reject all status"; it was "pursue status only where it *also* increases your power to act." Read correctly, it asks the insecure to do precisely what the objection says they must — seek the means to act — so the charge does not land. So I **revise** the claim to state openly that it welcomes capability-buying status for everyone, those not yet secure most of all, which sharpens it rather than abandoning it; and I **hold** the core against the charge, once its false premise is removed. What survives is a sharper thesis: seek the status that enlarges what you can do — whoever you are and wherever you start — and be suspicious, with Seneca, of the status you want only because the crowd wants it for you.

5. The consequences drawn.

Take the sharpened thesis seriously and it makes concrete demands. It tells me to weigh any prestigious offer by a test the salary does not answer — *will this role enlarge what I can actually do, or only how I look?* — and to be ready to decline the impressive job that shrinks me. It tells me to treat security and connections as *instruments*, banked for the capability they buy and not hoarded as trophies. And it asks something genuinely costly: to give up the steady reassurance of the external scoreboard, and to run Seneca's subtraction on my own ambitions often enough that it stays uncomfortable. That is what this account of success asks of a life — not a slogan, but a standing way of choosing.

Notice what the defence does. It does not shout the conclusion louder. It concedes a fair point, locates the false premise the objection rests on, revises where revision is owed and holds where it is not. That is what a good defence looks like.

7.2. Being your own adversary

With a live opponent, others supply the objections. Alone, you must supply them yourself, and be as hard on your own thesis as a hostile examiner would be. The following six standard objections apply to almost any thesis about the good life. Run every one against your claim before you consider it finished.

Method 7 (the six standard objections).

1. **Vague term.** Your key word (“flourishing,” “power to act,” “success”) is undefined. Give a case where it clearly fails to apply, or admit it means whatever you want it to mean. (This is the conceptualising of Chapter 4, turned on yourself.)
2. **Counterexample.** Here is a person who has what your thesis prizes and is plainly living badly (or lacks it and is plainly living well). Your thesis says the opposite.
3. **Hidden value.** Your thesis quietly assumes a value you have not defended (for example, that autonomy matters more than belonging). Defend it.
4. **Not universal.** Does this hold for everyone, or only for people like you? Name whom it fails for.
5. **Self-defeat.** By your own criterion, is holding this thesis actually good for you? If not, it undercuts itself.
6. **So what?** Once clarified, your claim is either false or trivially true. Which is it?

Pitfall. The most damaging shortcut is the **straw man**: stating a weak, easily-defeated version of the counter-argument so that you can knock it down. Graders and peers see it instantly, and it shows you have not understood the strongest case against yourself. The **steel man** is required instead: state the objection in the most forceful form you can, *as if you held it*, and only then answer it. A thesis that survives its own strongest objection is worth far more than one that defeats a feeble one.

7.3. Revising, and holding your ground

The point of exposing your thesis to objection is not to abandon it at the first push, nor to cling to it at any cost. It is to do exactly one of two things, for reasons.

Method 8 (revise or hold).

- **Revise** when the objection is *sound* — its premises hold and its inference lands. Concede the true part and repair the claim so that it accommodates the point. A thesis improved under a sound objection is stronger, not weaker.
- **Hold** when the objection is *not* sound — a false premise, a broken inference, or a conclusion that overreaches (run the three checks on the objection itself). Then say precisely *why* it fails, and keep your claim.

The one thing you may not do is decide in advance. Which way you go must be forced by the objection, not by your attachment to the thesis.

7.4. Drawing the consequences

A thesis defended is not yet a thesis finished. The final move is to ask what your account of success, now that it has survived objection, actually *asks of a life*: what it commits you to, what it rules out, and what it would change in how you choose. A thesis that stops at “here is what success is” has told you what to believe and not what to do. Drawing the consequences closes that gap — and it is the step on which the essay ends.

Method 9 (drawing the consequences).

1. **Ask what the thesis demands.** If this is what success is, what does a life organised around it require — of your choices, your commitments, what you pursue and what you refuse?
2. **Draw only what follows.** Each consequence must be entailed by the thesis as defended, not imported from what you happened to prefer beforehand. Run check 3 of Chapter 3 on your own consequences: granting the thesis, does this really follow?
3. **Include the costly ones.** State what the thesis asks that is hard — what it makes you give up — not only the consequences you find congenial. A list that only flatters the thesis has not been drawn honestly.

Pitfall. Two failures spoil this step. The first is **restating the thesis** instead of drawing from it: “so success is power to act” is the claim again, not a consequence of it. A genuine consequence names something the thesis *does* — a choice it forces, a comfort it removes. The second is the **non-sequitur consequence**: a practical conclusion that sounds weighty but does not actually follow from the thesis you defended. Draw what the thesis entails, and nothing more.

7.5. Defending under pressure, and composing the essay

The live defence brings back Chapter 3. Under objection you must, in real time, run the three checks on the attack (is the objector’s premise true? does the inference follow?) and on your own reply. A good defence is not louder insistence. It is showing exactly *where* the objection fails, or conceding the point and repairing the thesis. The worked thesis above did the second: it gave ground on the true part and came out sharper.

The written essay is this same movement, set down in order: state the claim; put two of the five criteria into productive tension; raise the strongest counter-argument, steel-manned; answer it, revising or holding for reasons; and draw the consequence — what your account of success asks of a life. Rigour is marked, not agreement: premises, inferences, whether the conclusion follows, and how the objection is handled.

One part of this cannot be rehearsed on the page. The six standard objections are the ones *you* thought of, and so the ones you were already braced for; real pressure comes from an objection you did not see coming, pressed by someone who will push where it hurts. To approximate it, do the final rehearsal **out loud**: hand a friend or study partner the six standard objections and your thesis, and have them fire the objections at you in an order you do not know, following up on your weakest answer. A book can give you the objections; only a live opponent can supply the surprise.

Exercises

7.1. Here is a claim: “To succeed is to live a life of maximum freedom, with as few obligations to others as possible.” Using the six standard objections, write the single strongest counter-argument to it, stated as if you held it (steel-man it, do not straw-man it).

7.2. Take the claim in Exercise (1) together with the objection you wrote. Now *answer* your own objection. Your answer must either show where the objection fails — a false premise, a broken inference, or a conclusion that overreaches — and hold, or concede a fair point and repair the claim, and revise; and it must say which it is doing and why.

7.3. Put two of the five criteria from Chapter 6 into *productive tension* over a single goal (for instance, Seneca versus Mill on chasing recognition). Show what work the disagreement does that citing either one alone would not.

7.4. Take the sharpened thesis of the worked example — “seek the status that enlarges what you can do” — and *draw its consequences*: state two things it asks of a life, one you find congenial and one you find costly. For each, show that it follows from the thesis (check 3 of Chapter 3) rather than merely restating it.

7.5. Capstone. Construct your own thesis on what it means to succeed, carrying all five parts (claim; two thinkers in productive tension; a steel-manned counter-argument; an answer defended against further objection; and the consequences drawn). Then run all six standard objections against it and note, for each, whether your thesis survives — and if not, whether you revise or hold, and why.

Answers. (1) A strong steel-man uses the counterexample and hidden-value objections together: “Maximum freedom with minimal obligation describes a lonely and shrinking life, not a successful one. The goods that make a life worth living — friendship, love, meaningful work, raising others — are all built out of obligations freely taken on. Aristotle’s flourishing needs them, and even Spinoza’s power to act grows through connection, not isolation. The thesis has quietly assumed that obligation is a cost rather than, often, the very thing that enlarges us.” A weak straw-man to avoid: “So you want no friends at all?” (2) A good answer **revises**: concede that *chosen* obligations can enlarge us, then repair the claim to prize not “as few obligations as possible” but “obligations you have genuinely chosen over ones imposed by inertia or others’ expectations.” That keeps a real thesis (success as authorship of your commitments) while surrendering the indefensible part (obligation as always a cost) — and it says openly that it is revising, because the objection’s core was sound. (3) For example: Seneca distrusts recognition as the crowd’s approval, which would not survive his subtraction; Mill notes recognition still adds real well-being and can open doors to more. The tension forces a condition — pursue recognition only where it converts into goods that survive Seneca’s subtraction — which neither thinker states alone. (4) A good answer draws consequences that *act*, not restatements: a congenial one such as “I can pursue a demanding, capability-building role with a clear conscience, even when it looks less glamorous than the alternative,” and a costly one such as “I must be ready to turn down the more prestigious, better-paid job when it would shrink what I can actually do — and give up the reassurance the title would have bought.” Each must follow from “seek the status that enlarges what you can do”: the test is that dropping the thesis would remove the consequence, which a mere restatement fails. (5) Self-check: your thesis passes only if (i) the claim could be argued against, (ii) the two thinkers actually disagree and the disagreement does work, (iii) the objection is one you would find hard to answer, not a soft target, (iv) for at least one of the six objections you had to either revise the claim or give a real reason for holding it, and (v) the consequences you draw genuinely follow from the defended thesis and include at least one that costs you something. A thesis that survived all six untouched, or whose consequences merely restate it, has almost certainly not been pushed hard enough.

Going to the source (optional). This book deliberately avoids “what did X believe.” But if you want to read an original after meeting an instrument, one short starting point each: Plato, *Euthyphro* and *Laches* (Socratic questioning and aporia); Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics* (eudaimonia); Epictetus, *Handbook (Enchiridion)* (the dichotomy of control); Spinoza, *Ethics* (the conatus and the emotions); Seneca, *On the Happy Life (De vita beata)*; Mill, *Utilitarianism* (what happiness is). None is required. Each repays the reading only once you already hold the idea as a tool.